/whatever you do

BEFORE YOU START

Workbook 1: How to use it

This is one of four workbooks that cover the middle of the course.

Your gifts How you've been designed - your strengths, according to you and others. **This workbook**

The space of your life Mapping your story, and what has happened in each season of it.

Expressing your calling Narrowing it to a sentence, then opening it back up.

Your growth plan Turning all of it into something you will actually do.

THREE THINGS WORTH REMEMBERING

This is not a test. Nobody marks it and nobody else reads it unless you choose to show them. An honest half-answer is worth more than a tidy one.

It is meant to be unhurried. Three or four sittings of half an hour is better than one long evening. The thinking needs time to settle.

You are not meant to do it alone. There are conversations with your coach built into each booklet. They matter more than any single page in it.

WHAT YOUR COACH IS FOR

A coach is not a mentor handing down their own experience. Their job is to ask questions and let you find your own answers. If they start telling you what they would do, it is entirely fair to point that out.

You will need a pen, a Bible, and somewhere you're unlikely to be interrupted. Your 'gifts and talents' results may not be fully complete, as it can take a while to get others to provide their assessments of you - don't let that stop you making progress on this workbook.

HOW TO GET THE MOST FROM THE BIBLE READINGS

These devotional materials are designed to provide the New Testament backdrop to your ongoing consideration of what Christian work and calling is.

Read them slowly. Read them multiple times. Pray through them. Underline bits, meditate on them. Memorise them, and write down what you sense the Holy Spirit might be saying to you as you do all of the above. The Bible passages, by definition, are God speaking. Embrace His words, listen as attentively as you can. To keep this sustainable, we'd recommend you swap it out for your quiet times, rather than treating it as additional material.

READING 1 OF 2

Matthew 11: 28-30

Start from rest, not striving

As we begin a season of considering our 'work' and calling, let's start from a place of rest, not striving. At the heart of the gospel is the reality that **the work that matters far more than any other is the work of Jesus**. His grace means that work and calling aren't heavy obligations to tick off a list to please God.

Instead, they are an opportunity to experience what his 'easy yoke' and 'light burden' look like in our lives. Most of all, let's start by accepting Jesus' invitation - "Come to me" - draw near, spend time in my presence... "and I will give you rest". **To know our calling, we need to know the one who calls us.**

> *"You don't need to unburden or collect yourself and then come to Jesus. Your very burden is what qualifies you to come. No payment is required; he says, "I will give you rest." His rest is gift, not transaction. Whether you are actively working hard to crowbar your life into smoothness ("labour") or passively finding yourself weighed down by something outside your control ("heavy laden"), Jesus Christ's desire that you find rest, that you come in out of the storm, outstrips even your own."*
>
> — Dane C. Ortlund, Gentle and Lowly: The Heart of Christ for Sinners and Sufferers

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— 'Gentle', 'humble', the one who gives an 'easy yoke' and a 'light burden' - do you know Jesus to be like this?

— Is anything 'wearying' you? What 'burdens' are you carrying that aren't from God?

— What do practices of rest and sabbath look like in your life at the moment?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship Jesus! He is full of gentleness and humility, not a brutal taskmaster

— Repentance for areas of our lives where we are 'working' to earn God's approval, rather than serving Him out of gratitude

— Asking to experience Jesus' nearness and rest, at the start of this exploration of calling

READING 2 OF 2

Ephesians 2: 4-10

Made, and made for something

Many of us are deeply familiar with verses 4 to 9. They are rich, glorious and encouraging. Salvation through faith alone means we can't - and don't have to try to - strain and strive to 'make up for' our sins. And we're not 'just' saved - we are 'made alive', 'seated with heavenly places', and will experience 'the immeasurable riches of His grace'.

But far too often, we stop there, and don't read verse 10. We love God's rich mercy, His saving grace, His unearned gift of salvation towards us, and rightly so.

But the gospel is more than that. **The gospel is also that we are designed by a creator, and that He has made us for a purpose. That He has prepared things for us to do for Him. To work, not to earn His love or our salvation, but out of gratitude for what God has done,** and also in recognition that it's part of our design.

> *"Grace is not opposed to effort, it is opposed to earning"*
>
> — Dallas Willard, The Great Omission

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

write your answers below

— In your daily life or weekly rhythms, how do you remind yourself of God's rich mercy, great love, grace in kindness towards you?

— When you reflect on being 'God's workmanship', do you have any ideas about what good works God has prepared for you to walk in?

SUGGESTED PRAYER POINTS

journal your prayers below, and any answers or prompting you receive

— Worship! Thank God the Father that He loved us when we were dead in our sins, for making us alive in Christ, for seating us in heavenly places, and everything else in this incredible passage

— Confessing any times where you've tried to earn God's approval

— Asking for the Holy Spirit to help you spot the specific ways in which you've been 'designed', and the specific 'good works that God has prepared beforehand' for you

CONVERSATION ONE

Talking it through

Show your coach the gifts and talents results you got in advance – your own answers, and the answers provided by others. Give your coach this page to steer this discussion.

FOR THE COACH · ABOUT 60 MINUTES

What this conversation is for

Helping them read their results as a starting point, not a verdict. They should come away owning what God has given them, including what others can see that they can't. The app has already done the scoring. Your job is not to interpret it, but to ask what they make of it. Read their results once before you meet, and note two or three things you're curious about rather than conclusions you've reached.

Depending on how quickly their 'trusted contacts' provided an answer to their strength survey, this may be your first coaching conversation, so spend the first ten minutes agreeing when you'll meet, and pray together. Remind them that you're there to ask questions, not give answers.

EXAMPLE QUESTIONS TO ASK

"What did you feel when you first saw your results? What surprised you?"
"Where do you and the people who know you agree? Where do they see something you don't?"
"Which strength are you quickest to play down, and why that one?"
"Is this what you're naturally good at, or what your current role has made you practise?"
"What drains you most, and how much of your week does it take up at the moment?"

WHAT TO LOOK OUT FOR

Brushing off encouragement. Playing a gift down isn't humility. If they wave something away, ask them to say it back in their own words.

Fixating on weaknesses, or who said what. This is about identifying gifts. Steer away from rumination about respondents kindly. The answers are anonymous so that people could be honest.

Treating the results as a verdict or a job title. They describe how someone tends to contribute, not what they should do for a living. A joint top gift or an even spread is useful information, not a failure.

A gap between their view and others' can be a blind spot, or a gift used where those people never see them. Ask before deciding which.

AVOID Imposing your own reading of their story. Ask what they see before offering what you see.

To close, ask them what – if anything – they'd like to add to the sheet with their results on it, the 'two or three strengths they are 'most willing to own'. **Remind them to go back to the online tool and download the next workbook.**